

C4TO

CLEARED FOR TAKE-OFF ACADEMY

AI for Grown-Ups

COMPANION GUIDE

The Tool Hangar

Guide to the Wider Fleet

Every kind of AI tool, organised by the job you want done

All students · Reference guide, visit when a job calls for it

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Contents

Before we start

Welcome to the Tool Hangar. This is not Module 7, and it is absolutely not homework. Think of it as the big shed out the back of the academy where the rest of the fleet is parked: the search tools, the image makers, the song writers, the video machines, and the AI that has quietly moved into apps you already use every day. You don't work through this guide from front to back, and there is no Cleared To Try at the end. You come out here when a job calls for it: a flyer to make, a song for an anniversary, a pile of documents to dig through. The rest of the time, the hangar doors stay shut and your core crew handles the week perfectly well.

If you've finished the six modules, everything here will feel familiar: the same Captain's seat, the same controls, simply more aircraft. If you're partway through the course, that's fine too; nothing in the hangar needs skills you haven't met by Module 2, and anything that touches on safety points you straight back to Module 5. And if a section doesn't apply to your life, skip it without a flicker of guilt. There is no test on the hangar.

One thing to know before we walk in. This corner of the AI world is where the names churn fastest. Tools launch, merge, rename themselves and vanish, and the breathless headlines make it sound like you're falling behind on a weekly basis. You are not. Jobs don't churn: people will still want to make a birthday card, research a decision and tidy up the family photos in ten years, whatever the tools are called by then. So this hangar is organised by the job you want done, never by the brand. Learn the jobs, and the names can do whatever they like.

A word on money, since it always comes up. Almost everything in this guide has a free tier at the time of writing: enough to try the tool properly and to handle the occasional job. Paid versions typically cost roughly the same as a streaming subscription. The course rule applies out here too: never pay for a tool until you've hit the free version's limits doing real jobs, and never hand over a credit card just to have a first conversation.

New in this edition. Every first-choice tool now has its own short lesson in the companion selector, First Flights: Choose Your Aircraft. The choosing table at the back of this guide is the hub that connects each job to its tool and its lesson. If you read only one part of this guide, read that table.

How this guide is organised

Seven hangars, numbered for parking, not for lesson order. Hangar 1 holds your core crew, recapped briefly. Hangars 2 to 5 hold the specialists: search and research, images and design, music and voice, video. Hangar 6 covers the AI already living inside your everyday apps, and Hangar 7 handles the other names you'll hear at barbecues. At the back there's a single choosing table that does the work of the whole building, and the hangar rules to carry out the door with you.

The one big idea

Every AI tool runs on the same literacy: brief, steer, verify, decide.

The four flight controls from Module 2 (context, task, format, tone) work in every tool in this guide. A tool that makes images instead of paragraphs still wants to know the situation, the job, the shape and the feel. You already speak the language of this entire hangar; everything else is local accents.

Meeting any new aircraft: the five-minute checklist

The Module 1 checklist works on every tool in this guide, and on every tool that launches after it. Five minutes, every time:

1. Go in through the official site or app store, never through a link in an ad or a text.
2. Sign up safely: a name and an email, nothing more.
3. Find the privacy or training toggle and switch training off.
4. Apply the never-share list: no passwords, full card numbers, government IDs, or other people's details.
5. Say a small hello before you trust it with anything that matters.

And one hangar-wide rule: if a tool has no way to turn training off, fly it with nothing personal aboard. Use it for the job; keep your life out of the cargo hold.

Each hangar below tells you what lives there, what it's genuinely good at as a first job, and where the cautions are. The Captain's hat stays on throughout: every tool here does legwork, and every decision stays yours.

Hangar 1: The chat assistants (your core crew)

You know these four. The whole course is flown with them, and they carry a good 90% of everyday jobs: writing, summarising, planning, researching, explaining, thinking out loud. If you remember nothing else from this guide, remember this: when in doubt, start with your chat assistant. It's usually the right aircraft for the job, and when it isn't, it will happily tell you what is.

ChatGPT	OpenAI's. The best-known: friendly, general, big free version.	You want the most-discussed all-rounder.
Claude	Anthropic's. Natural, careful writing and a calm tone.	Your jobs are mainly writing and thinking.
Gemini	Google's. Sits close to Gmail, Docs and Android.	Your life runs on Google.
Copilot	Microsoft's. Sits close to Windows and Office.	Your life runs on Windows and Office.

Everything in Modules 1 to 6 (the four controls, the flight pattern, the rule of two, the never-share list) was learned on these four, and everything below assumes it. The hangars that follow hold specialists: aircraft you roll out for particular jobs, not replacements for your crew.

One reminder worth its hangar space: your skills transfer. A Captain who can brief one of these can brief all four, so a second opinion from a different crew member costs nothing but a sign-up. Plenty of students quietly keep two: one main crew for the everyday, one for second opinions on facts and big decisions. That's the rule of two with wings on.

→ *Lessons: ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini and Copilot each have a full First Flight lesson. Start with whichever door fits your life.*

Hangar 2: Search and research

Chat assistants write fresh answers in their own words; search tools find things and show you where they found them. When the job is "what's true, and where does it say so?", this hangar earns its keep.

Perplexity

Perplexity is an AI search engine. You ask in plain English, it answers in plain English, and (this is the lovely part) it shows its sources as it goes, with small numbered citations you can click. That suits the rule of two beautifully: the answer arrives already holding the receipts you would otherwise have to ask for. Free tier at the time of writing, with a paid version for heavier use.

NotebookLM

NotebookLM is Google's research tool, with a twist that matters: it answers only from documents you give it. Load in your insurance policies, the strata minutes, Grandad's letters or your own forty-page family history draft, then ask questions of that material and nothing else. Because it can't wander off into the wider internet, it can't bring back the wider internet's nonsense. For digging through your own files, it is quietly brilliant.

The search modes inside your core four

ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini and Copilot all have search modes that look things up on the live web and cite their sources. For most everyday research you may not need a new tool at all: just make sure search is switched on, and ask the crew to show its sources.

Which to choose? If the answer should come with receipts (health claims, prices, rules, anything you'll repeat to another adult), reach for Perplexity or a search mode. If the answer is buried in paperwork you already own, NotebookLM. And if you're still working out what question to ask, start with your crew and let the conversation sharpen it first; a well-shaped question makes every search tool better.

Good first jobs

- Ask Perplexity: "What does recent research say about strength training after 60? Show your sources."
- Load your phone, energy and insurance policies into NotebookLM and ask: "What am I actually covered for, and what are the exclusions?"
- Ask your chat assistant, in search mode: "What's the current rule on [the thing you're deciding], and where does it say so officially?"

The cautions

A citation is a pointer, not a guarantee. Sources can be thin: a blog quoting a forum quoting a guess still gets a tidy little number next to it. Click at least one source before you act on anything, and prefer the official one. The rule of two has not retired; it has simply been handed better paperwork.

→ *Lessons: see the Perplexity and NotebookLM First Flight lessons.*

Hangar 3: Images and design

This hangar turns plain English into pictures. No drawing skill is required; describing skill is the whole game, and you trained that in Module 2.

The image makers inside ChatGPT and Gemini

Both ChatGPT and Gemini can make images right inside the chat you already use. Describe what you want the way you'd describe it to a helpful artist: the scene, the style, the mood, what matters most. Then steer, exactly as you do with words: "warmer", "simpler", "more like a watercolour", "the dog should look happier". It's the same brief-and-steer loop you already know, with paint instead of paragraphs.

Two habits make image tools click quickly. First, expect to go around again: the first image is a first draft, exactly like a first draft of writing, and "again, but..." is a complete instruction. Second, say what matters most: "the kookaburra is the hero of the picture" gets you a better card than a paragraph of scenery. The third and fourth flight controls do real work here too: "in the style of a vintage travel poster" or "soft, warm, hand-drawn" changes everything.

Canva

Canva is a design app with AI woven all the way through it, and it is the friendliest door into design for a beginner. Where the image makers hand you a picture, Canva hands you a finished thing: a birthday card with your words on it, a flyer with the date and the contact details laid out properly, a poster sized for the community noticeboard. Free tier at the time of writing; the paid version costs roughly the same as a streaming subscription.

Midjourney

Midjourney is the artists' choice: the tool behind many of the most striking AI images you've seen. It's paid, and the learning curve is steeper than anything else in this hangar. Visit when you've caught the art bug, not before.

Good first jobs

- A birthday card with an image nobody could buy in a shop: "a watercolour of a grey-haired woman triumphantly finishing a crossword, morning light, warm and gentle".
- A flyer for the community group's plant sale, made in Canva over a cup of tea.
- A cover for the family history you've been writing with your crew since Module 4.

The cautions

Don't make images of real people without their OK. A joke image of a friend is still an image of them that they never agreed to.

And be aware: AI images of celebrities and news events are exactly how deepfakes start. Your Module 5 radar applies in both directions here: be hard to fool, and never make anything that would fool somebody else.

→ *Lessons: see the Canva First Flight lesson. Midjourney has a shorter spotlight lesson.*

Hangar 4: Music and voice

The most unexpected delight in the building. The first time a finished song plays with your words in it, sounding like it came off the radio, is a genuine jaw-drop moment, and it takes about five minutes.

Suno

Suno writes and performs songs from a plain-English description. Tell it the occasion, the style and what to mention: "a warm folk song for Helen and Bob's 50th wedding anniversary, mentioning the caravan, the rose garden, and meeting at the Saturday dance in 1974", and a few minutes later there is a song, sung, with verses and a chorus. Free tier at the time of writing. For birthdays, anniversaries, farewells and family Christmases it is wonderful: nobody forgets the year there was a song.

ElevenLabs

ElevenLabs turns text into natural-sounding speech: a real-sounding voice with breath and warmth in it, not a robot reading the weather. Use it to narrate the family history into an audiobook, to give a slideshow a proper voice-over, or to hear your own memoir read aloud while you do the dishes. It can also clone a specific voice, with consent: your own voice, recorded for the purpose, so the audiobook of your memoir can be read by you.

As with images, the brief does the heavy lifting. For Suno, name the style and era you actually like: "gentle country waltz", "sixties pop with harmonies". For narration, paste one paragraph and audition a few voices before settling in; the right voice for a memoir is rarely the right voice for a community announcement. Both tools reward exactly the steering you learned in Module 2, one polite request at a time.

Good first jobs

- A song for the next big family occasion, with three details only your family would recognise.
- One chapter of the memoir, narrated, as a gift for the grandchildren.
- A proper send-off song for a colleague's retirement, premiered at the morning tea.

The caution that matters here

Voice cloning is the same technology behind the scam calls you met in Module 5. That's not a reason to avoid it; it is a reason to respect it. Clone only your own voice, or a voice whose owner has given you explicit permission, and never use a cloned voice to pretend to be someone. The family safe word exists because not everyone follows this rule.

→ *Lessons: see the Suno and ElevenLabs First Flight lessons.*

Hangar 5: Video

The newest hangar, and the one changing fastest. OpenAI's Sora and Google's Veo turn plain-English descriptions into short video clips: a koala surfing at sunset, the farm as it might have looked in 1950, a birthday message with film-trailer production values. Mostly paid at the time of writing, still maturing, and improving at a startling rate.

You'll also meet video in small doses without seeking it out: short AI clips are already woven through social media feeds, which is one more reason the Module 5 radar matters. If a video of a famous person seems built to make you angry, amazed, or suddenly interested in an investment, remember how cheaply such things are now made, and how good they have become.

An honest note

Lovely for play and family projects; not yet an everyday tool. The clips are short, the costs are real, and the results can be gloriously strange (count the fingers). Our advice: enjoy whatever trickles into the free tiers of the tools you already use, and have a proper look at this hangar at one of your quarterly check-ins, the Module 6 habit. It will be a different hangar every time you visit, and one visit it will be ready for you.

→ *Lessons: Sora and Veo are awareness only for now; visit at a quarterly check-in. For editing video you already have, see the CapCut First Flight lesson in the selector.*

Hangar 6: The AI already inside your apps

You don't have to seek AI out anymore; it has moved in. The assistants in this hangar live inside apps you already open every day, which makes them the AI you will bump into whether you go looking or not. Worth knowing on purpose, rather than meeting by accident.

Meta AI, inside WhatsApp, Facebook and Instagram

That blue-and-purple circle, or the search bar inviting you to "Ask Meta AI", is Meta's assistant, built into WhatsApp, Facebook and Instagram. It answers questions, settles dinner-table debates and finds things without you leaving the chat. Fine for quick lookups. But remember: your chats with

Meta AI are not your private crew conversations. You haven’t set its privacy toggles, and it lives inside a social media company. Treat it like chatting at a barbecue: pleasant, useful, and not the place for anything personal.

Copilot inside Word, Excel and Outlook

If you use Microsoft Office, often through a Microsoft 365 subscription or a work account, Copilot appears right inside Word, Excel and Outlook: drafting the document where the document lives, summarising the inbox in the inbox. It’s the same crew member you may already know from the course, standing where you work. At the office, the usual line applies: your employer’s AI rules outrank everything in this guide.

Gmail’s writing help

Gmail offers writing help right in the compose window: drafting a reply, polishing your version, “make it more formal”, “shorten it”. Handy for quick everyday email. For anything tricky or sensitive, step over to your crew, where you can brief properly with the four controls.

Expect this hangar to keep growing. Phones, banks, supermarkets and government services are all adding assistants, each with its own memory and its own rules. The habit that keeps you safe never changes: pause for one second and ask, “Who am I actually talking to, and did I ever set its privacy toggles?” If the answer is no, keep the conversation light.

The point of this hangar

Know which assistant you’re talking to before you share anything.

The button inside a social app, the helper inside your word processor, and your own privacy-toggled crew are three different conversations with three different memories. The never-share list applies everywhere; extra caution applies wherever you never set the toggles yourself.

→ *Lessons: Copilot has a full First Flight lesson; Meta AI is awareness only. Treat Gmail's writing help as covered by your core-crew lessons.*

Hangar 7: Other names you’ll hear

A short hangar for the names that come up at barbecues, so none of them can make you feel behind.

Grok

Grok is the assistant built into X, the platform formerly known as Twitter. If you use X you’ll see it offering to explain posts and answer questions, with a deliberately cheekier personality than the others. The same chat skills apply, and so does the same checklist.

DeepSeek

DeepSeek is a capable free chat tool that made world headlines for matching the majors at a fraction of the cost. An honest assessment: the chat is genuinely good, but the privacy controls are weaker and the data handling is less transparent than the majors. So apply the hangar-wide rule from the front of this guide: nothing personal aboard. Recipes, trivia, word games and general questions, happily; your life, no.

And whatever launches next month

There will always be a new name. That’s the weather in this industry, not a storm. The test for any new name is the same five-minute Module 1 checklist from the front of this guide: official site, safe sign-up, find the training toggle, never-share list, small hello. A tool that passes is just another aircraft, and you already know how to fly it. A tool with no training toggle gets the nothing-personal rule. A tool that fails the sign-up test (a credit card just to chat, arrived as a link in a text, pressure to hurry) gets left on the tarmac.

→ *Lessons: Grok and DeepSeek are awareness only, covered in your quarterly updates. No name here can leave you behind.*

Choosing from the hangar

Here is the whole guide as one table. Find the job in the left column, start with the first choice, and treat the right column as your backup or your upgrade. When no row fits, start with your chat assistant and ask it what it would use.

Write or reply to anything	Your chat assistant	Gmail’s writing help or Copilot in Outlook for quick ones
Summarise a long document	Your chat assistant	NotebookLM when there’s a whole pile of them
Plan a trip, event or project	Your chat assistant	A second opinion from a different crew member
Research with sources showing	Perplexity	Your chat assistant with search mode on
Dig through my own documents	NotebookLM	Your chat assistant, with the documents pasted in
Make an image from a description	ChatGPT or Gemini	Midjourney, once you’ve caught the art bug
Design a card, flyer or poster	Canva	An image from ChatGPT or Gemini, finished in Canva
Make a song for an occasion	Suno	Your crew for the lyrics first, then Suno to sing them
Narrate text aloud	ElevenLabs	The read-aloud button in your chat assistant
Quick lookup inside WhatsApp	Meta AI	Your crew’s own app, for anything personal

→ *Each tool in the First choice column has its own lesson in First Flights: Choose Your Aircraft. This table is the hub; the lessons are the hangars it opens into.*

Two practical notes on the table. “Your chat assistant” means whichever of the core four you fly; the rows work the same in all of them. And the table is a starting grid, not a rulebook: if your crew turns out to be wonderful at a job listed elsewhere, fly what works. The aim was never tool collecting; it’s the shortest calm path from job to done.

Notice what the middle column mostly says. The hangar is full of marvels, but the chat assistant you set up in Module 1 remains the most useful aircraft in the building, and the one that makes all the others easier to learn.

The hangar rules

Same rules, every aircraft

Same Captain. You decide what gets made, sent, sung and shared. No tool in this hangar ever gets the controls.

Same controls. Brief, steer, verify, decide. Context, task, format, tone. The literacy carries everywhere.

Same never-share list. No tool needs your passwords, full card numbers, government IDs or other people’s details. Not one, not ever.

Same rule of two. Any fact you’re going to act on gets one independent check, whichever aircraft produced it.

And the Module 6 line: visit when a job calls for it, not before. The hangar is a resource, not a curriculum, and it will keep.

A final note on names and prices

Tool names, free tiers and features change; that is the one reliably true fact in this guide. Everything here is accurate at the time of writing and is refreshed with the course's quarterly updates, so make sure you're reading the current copy from the course library. And whenever this guide and a tool's official site disagree, the official site wins.

Happy flying, Captain. The hangar doors are always open, and nothing in here ever needs to be learned in advance. Pick the job, roll out the aircraft, and bring your same steady hands.